The Clown of God

By Tomie dePaola

INTRODUCTION

(Hum a few lines from The Little Drummer Boy)

It was Saint Therese of Lisieux who said: "You know well enough that Our Lord does not look so much at the greatness of our actions, nor even at their difficulty, but at the love with which we do them." This was true of America's Little Drummer boy and can be found in many legends and fables world-wide. A poor soul with little worthy to give a King, but with a heart so big, so open – that in itself becomes a gift.

based upon a French legend . . . The Clown of God by Tomie dePaola

NARRATOR: Many, many years ago, in Sorrento . . . there lived a small boy named Giovanni who had no mother and not father. He dressed in rags and begged his bread and slept in doorways. But he was happy, and he could do something wonderful. He could juggle. Every day he would go to Signor Baptista's fruit and vegetable stall and juggle.

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He would juggle lemons and oranges, apples and eggplants, and even zucchini. Crowds would gather to watch, and when Giovanni had finished, they would buy from Signor Baptista. Then Signor Baptista's wife would give Giovanni a bowl of hot soup. It was a very good arrangement.

One day a troupe of traveling players came to town, and Giovani watched as Arlecchino and Colombina*, in their beautiful clothes, danced and sang.

GIOVANNI: *(wonderstruck)* Oh, that is the life for me!

NARRATOR: So when the play was over, Giovanni went and spoke to the Maestro.

MAESTRO: No, no. I have no need for a ragamuffin. Go beg your bread somewhere else.

GIOVANNI: *(pleading)* But I could be very helpful. I could help unpack and pack up. I could take care of the donkey, And, Maestro . . . . I can ***juggle***! *(he demonstrates)*

MAESTRO: Not bad. With a bit more training and practice . . . All right! But no money. A place to sleep, the

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companionship of the finest players in Italy, and a bowl of noodles. That's all.

GIOVANNI: Grazi, Signor.

MAESTRO: Go get your things. We leave in an hour.

NARRATOR: And so Giovanni said good-bye to Signor and Signora Baptista and became a traveling player.

Not long after, the Maestro gave him a costume and Giovanni juggled for the crowds. He would put on a clown face, step out from the curtain before the play began, bow, open up a colorful bag, roll out a carpet, and begin. He would juggle sticks. Plates. Then he would balance the plates on the sticks and twirl them. He would juggle clubs, rings, and burning torches.

Finally he would toss a red ball and an orange ball. Then a yellow ball. A green, a blue, and a violet ball until it looked as if he were juggling the rainbow.

GIOVANNI: And now for the Sun in the Heavens!

NARRATOR: Still juggling, he would pick up a shining golden ball and toss it higher and higher, faster and faster. And how the crows would cheer.

CROWD: *(cheering)*

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NARRATOR: Giovanni became very famous, and it wasn't long before he said good-bye to the traveling troupe and set off on his own. Up and down Italy he traveled, and although his costume became more beautiful, he always kept the face of a clown. Once he juggled for a duke. Once for a prince! And it was always the same.

First the sticks, then plates, then the clubs, rings, and burning torches. Finally the rainbow of colored balls.

GIOVANNI: And now for the Sun in the Heavens!

NARRATOR: And the golden ball would fly higher and higher and the crowds would laugh and clap and cheer. One day, between two towns, Giovanni was sitting in the shade of a tree, eating a lunch of bread and cheese. Two Little Brothers came down the road.

BROTHER: Will you share your food with us, good clown, for the love of God and the blessing of our Brother Francis?

GIOVANNI: Sit down, good fellows. There is more than enough.

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NARRATOR: As the three men ate, the two Little Brothers told Giovanni how they went from town, begging their food and spreading the joy of God.

BROTHER: Our founder, Brother Francis says that everything signs of the glory of God. Why, even your juggling.

GIOVANNI: That's well and good for men like you, but I only juggle to make people laugh and applaud.

BROTHER: It's the same thing. If you give happiness to people, you give glory to God as well.

GIOVANNI: *(laughing)* If you say so! But now I must be off to the next town. *Arrivederi*, good brothers – and good luck!

NARRATOR: Wherever Giovanni went, the air was filled with his flying sticks and plates, his clubs and rings and torches. And, always, his rainbow of balls and "the Sun in the Heavens." And wherever Giovanni went, the faces of the crowds would be all smiles, and the sound of laughter and cheers would ring through the towns. Years passed. Giovanni grew old and times became hard. People no longer stopped to watch.

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TOWNPERSON: It's only the old clown who juggles things. We've all seen him before.

NARRATOR: Giovanni was sad, but still he juggled, until one day he dropped "the Sun in the Heavens," and the rainbow of balls came crashing down and the crowd stood around him and laughed!

CROWD: *(pointing and laughing)*

NARRATOR: But not from joy. Then they did a terrible thing. They threw vegetables and stones at Giovanni, so that he had to run for his life.

Beside a stream, Giovanni took off his clown face. He put away his sticks and his plates, his clubs and rings and colored balls. He put away his costume and he gave up juggling forever. What little money he had soon was gone, and his clothes became rags. He begged his bread and slept in doorways as he had done as a child.

GIOVANNI: *(wearily)* It's time to go home.

NARRATOR: And he headed back to Sorrento. It was a cold winter night when he finally arrived. The wind blew hard, and an icy rain was falling. Up ahead loomed the monastery church of the Little Brothers.

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The windows were in darkness. Wet and cold, old Giovanni crept inside and fell in a heap in a corner. Soon he was asleep. (Giovanni snores softly)

It was the music that woke him up. The church was blazing with candlelight and filled with people singing

PEOPLE: *(singing)* Gloria! Gloria!

NARRATOR: Giovanni could scarcely believe his eyes. So much beauty! A long procession of brothers, priests, sisters and townspeople, all carrying beautiful gifts was winding its way through the church. They placed their gifts in front of a statute – of a lady and her child.

GIOVANNI: What is all this?

WOMAN: Why, old man, it's the birthday of the Holy Child. It's the procession of the gifts.

NARRATOR: Giovanni watched in amazement until the singing was over. Then the church emptied of all the people and was darkened except for the bright candles surrounding the Lady and the Child. Giovanni moved closer. The Child in the Lady's arms seemed so serious, so stern.

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GIOVANNI: *(kneeling)* Oh, Lady. I wish I had something to offer, too. Your child seems so dad, even with all these beautiful gifts. But wait – I used to make people smile.

NARRATOR: Giovanni opened his bag and shook out his old costume. Then he put on his clown face, bowed, rolled out the little rug, and began to juggle. First the sticks. Then the plates. Next he twirled the plates on the sticks. And then the clubs and rings . . .

The Brother Sexton, who was coming in to lock the doors, saw Giovanni juggling. He was horrified.

BROTHER SEXTON: Father Master! A sacrilege! Come quickly!

NARRATOR: But Giovanni didn't hear or notice him.

GIOVANNI: *(smiling at the Child)* And now . . . First the red ball, then the orange . . . Next the yellow. And the green, blue and violet.

NARRATOR: Around and up they went until they looked like a rainbow.

GIOVANNI: And finally . . . The Sun in the Heavens!

NARRATOR: The gold ball flew up and around and around, higher and higher. Giovanni had never juggled so well

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in all his life. Higher and higher, faster and faster. A blaze of color filled the air. It was magnificent! Giovanni's heart was pounding.

GIOVANNI: For You, sweet Child, for You! *(he suddenly collapses)*

NARRATOR: The priest and Brother Sexton came rushing in.

PRIEST: *(kneeling over Giovanni, he makes the sign of the cross)* Why, the poor clown is dead. May his soul rest in peace.

NARRATOR: But the Brother Sexton backed away . . .

BROTHER SEXTON: *(backing away, he gapes at the statue of the Lady and her Holy Child; he points)* Oh, Father! Oh, Father, look!

NARRATOR: The Child was smiling, and in His hand He held the golden ball.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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The **Arlecchino mask is one of the most popular masks in the Commedia dell'Arte series. Arlecchino's usual role is that of a faithful valet or servant, but in this context he is also the clown, the acrobat providing lots of comic relief! As soon as this character appears on stage there is always lots of laughter at his absurd actions and words, alternating between flashes of brilliance and plain idiocy. You can't predict which will manifest itself at any time! This is overlaid with wit and charm, as well as scheming to meet his own objectives.*

***Colombina** is usually cast as a mischievous maid in the Commedia dell'Arte, a comic but not always virtuous figure with a best friend (and sometimes lover) of Arlecchino.*

Music and Lyrics of Little Drummer Boy – Our favorite version is by Penatonix
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=qJ_MGWio-vc

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